

THE SKILL SEEKER LAB

THE SKILL SEEKER JOURNAL

A GUIDED PRACTICE JOURNAL

THE SKILL SEEKER JOURNAL

12 weeks. 72 guided sessions.
One skill you actually keep.

THE SKILL SEEKER LAB

The Skill Seeker Journal

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PROPERTY OF

NAME

THE SKILL I AM BUILDING

STARTED

FINISHED

If found, I would genuinely like this back:

How to use this journal

This is a working notebook, not a book you read. It runs for twelve weeks and asks for six short sessions a week — seventy-two in total. One skill. That is the whole design.

01 Choose once, properly.

Pages 11–14 walk you through picking a single skill and scoring it honestly. Do that section in one sitting, then stop choosing.

02 Sign the charter.

Page 13 turns the choice into a commitment with a time, a place and an amount. Vague intentions die in week two.

03 Brief the week.

Every week opens with a Week Brief: one focus, one rep to repeat, one obstacle plan. Two minutes on a Sunday.

04 Run the session, log the friction.

Each Daily Lab page takes three minutes after practice. The Friction Log is the most valuable field in this journal — where you got stuck is where the skill actually lives.

05 Debrief and adjust.

Each week closes with a Debrief: keep what worked, drop what didn't, change exactly one thing.

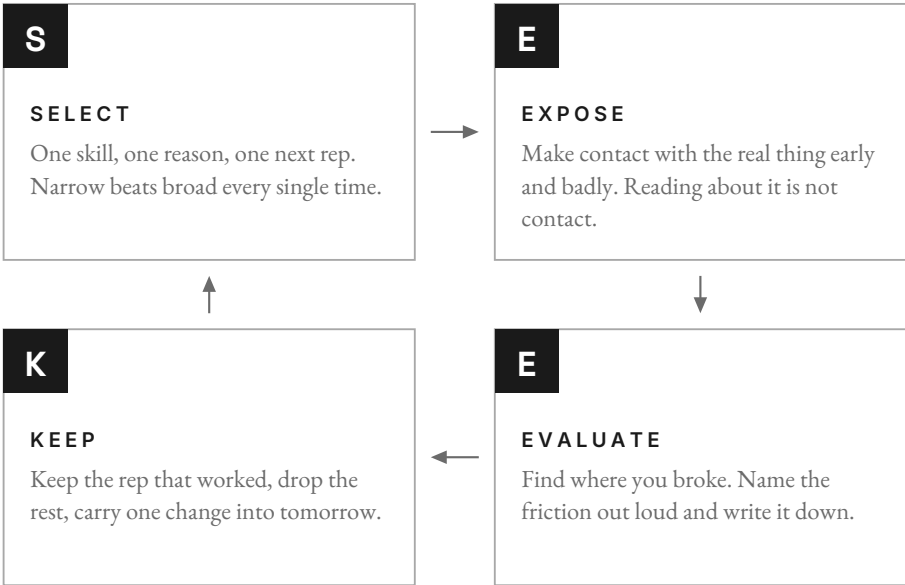
06 Bank the evidence.

The Evidence Ledger at the back is the proof. Hours are not progress. Things you made are progress.

Miss a day? Leave the page blank and carry on. This journal is built to survive gaps — it is not built to survive quitting.

The SEEK loop

Every session in this journal is one turn of the same four-step loop. Twelve weeks is just seventy-two turns.



WHAT ONE TURN LOOKS LIKE

Twenty-five minutes on a Tuesday. You **SELECT** one rep: “write a function that prints the longest line in a file.” You **EXPOSE** yourself to it by opening the editor instead of a tutorial. You **EVALUATE** — it broke on empty files and you don’t know why. You **KEEP** the habit of running it after every change, and tomorrow’s rep becomes “handle the empty case first.”

That is one line in the Friction Log and one in the fix box — three minutes of writing. Seventy-two of those and you are a different practitioner.

IF YOU ONLY EVER FILL IN ONE FIELD

Make it the Friction Log. Everything else here is scaffolding around one question: where exactly did it stop working, and what will I try next?

The five laws of skill seeking

LAW 01

One skill at a time.

Breadth is the reward for depth, never the route to it. Park the other three skills on page 11 and come back to them in April.

LAW 02

Reps beat research.

A bad attempt teaches you more in ten minutes than a good article teaches you in an hour. Buying the course is not doing the course.

LAW 03

Friction is the map.

The place you get stuck, avoid, or quietly skip is not an obstacle to the skill. It is the skill. Go straight at it.

LAW 04

Evidence over hours.

Nobody was ever good at something because they sat near it for forty hours. Log what you produced, not how long you suffered.

LAW 05

Small and daily.

Twenty protected minutes six days a week will beat four heroic hours once a fortnight, every time, without exception.

When a week goes wrong it is almost always because one of these five got quietly broken. Come back to this page and work out which one.

Skill selection lab

Twelve weeks is long enough to matter and short enough to finish. Spend twenty minutes here so you never have to reopen the question.

MY MAIN REASON FOR LEARNING SOMETHING NEW

- ☐ Career change
- ☐ Promotion
- ☐ Start a business
- ☐ Creative work
- ☐ Personal growth
- ☐ Curiosity
- ☐ Someone I want to help

THE FIELD OR INDUSTRY THAT PULLS ME MOST

THREE SKILLS I KEEP CIRCLING BACK TO

Write them down so you can stop carrying them around.

A

SO THAT I CAN

B

SO THAT I CAN

C

SO THAT I CAN

WHAT IS ACTUALLY STOPPING ME RIGHT NOW

THE HONEST CONSTRAINTS

- ☐ Time
- ☐ Money
- ☐ Confidence
- ☐ Focus
- ☐ Access to tools
- ☐ Nobody to ask
- ☐ Fear of looking stupid

THE BIGGEST ONE IS — AND HERE IS WHAT I WILL DO ABOUT IT

Score them, then choose

Score each skill 1–5 in all four columns and add up the rows. The highest total is your skill. If two tie, pick the one you are slightly afraid of.

- PULL — how much do I want this on a dull Tuesday?

PAYOFF — what does having it change about my life?

PROOF — can I show evidence of it within twelve weeks?

PRACTICAL — do I have the time, tools and money today?

	PULL	PAYOFF	PROOF	PRACT.	TOTAL
SKILL A					
SKILL B					
SKILL C					

MINUTES A DAY I CAN GENUINELY PROTECT — BE PESSIMISTIC

MY LEARNING BUDGET FOR THE NEXT TWELVE WEEKS

- ☐ Free only ☐ Under \$100 ☐ \$100–\$500 ☐ \$500+ ☐ No limit

THE SKILL I AM CHOOSING

THE TWO I AM PARKING UNTIL THIS IS FINISHED

SIGN IT

My skill charter

Intentions evaporate. Commitments with a time, a place and a number survive. Fill in every blank.

I AM LEARNING

BECAUSE IT WILL LET ME

BY THE END OF WEEK TWELVE I WILL HAVE MADE, DONE OR SHOWN

THE NON-NEGOTIABLE

I will practise _____ minutes a day, _____ days a week,
at _____ (time), at _____ (place).

MY VERY FIRST REP — SMALL ENOUGH TO DO TODAY

WHAT I AM GIVING UP TO MAKE THE ROOM

WHO I AM TELLING, SO THAT QUITTING IS AWKWARD

START DATE _____ WEEK 12 ENDS _____

Honest baseline

You cannot show progress you never measured. Be harsh here — a low baseline is a gift to your week-twelve self.

BREAK THE SKILL INTO SIX PARTS AND RATE EACH ONE TODAY

1 = no idea what this even means 10 = I could be paid for this

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
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_____	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
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WHAT I CAN ALREADY DO, WITHOUT HELP

WHAT I DEFINITELY CANNOT DO YET

THE LIE I HAVE BEEN TELLING MYSELF ABOUT THIS SKILL

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" WOULD HONESTLY LOOK LIKE IN TWELVE WEEKS

The twelve-week map

A rough sketch beats no sketch. Pencil it in now and change it whenever the work tells you to.

WEEK	FOCUS	EVIDENCE BY SUNDAY	DONE
01	Exposure — touch the real thing		☐
02	Fundamentals — name the parts		☐
03	First build — one whole thing		☐
04	Friction — attack what sticks		☐
05	Speed — the same rep, faster		☐
06	Depth — one layer underneath		☐
07	Feedback — show it to someone		☐
08	Repair — fix your weakest work		☐
09	Stretch — reach above your level		☐
10	Consolidate — teach and document		☐
11	Ship — finish one real artefact		☐
12	Proof — assemble the evidence		☐

The grey text is a suggested arc — write straight over it.

Week brief

Start before you are ready. Ready is something you build, not something you wait for.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

IF THAT HAPPENS, MY PLAN IS

RESOURCE I AM USING — COURSE, BOOK, PERSON, PROJECT

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

STARTENDTOTAL MIN

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID

FRICTION LOG — EXACTLY WHERE I GOT STUCK

THE FIX I WILL TRY NEXT TIME

EVIDENCE PRODUCED

☐ Made something

☐ Practised

☐ Taught it

☐ Applied it

☐ Failed usefully

DIFFICULTY

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FOCUS

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ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

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FOCUS (1) (2) (3) (4) (5)

ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

EVIDENCE I PRODUCED THIS WEEK — LIST IT, NO ADJECTIVES

WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL TODAY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

The first ten attempts are tuition. Pay them quickly and stop flinching.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

You never find time for a skill. You take it from something else. Decide what.

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SESSIONS PLANNED

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Week brief

Confusion is not failure. It is the sound of arriving at the edge of what you know.

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THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

Practise the part you avoid. That is the exact place the skill is hiding.

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SESSIONS PLANNED

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12345

FOCUS

12345

ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

START

END

TOTAL MIN

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID

FRICTION LOG — EXACTLY WHERE I GOT STUCK

THE FIX I WILL TRY NEXT TIME

EVIDENCE PRODUCED

☐ Made something ☐ Practised ☐ Taught it ☐ Applied it ☐ Failed usefully

DIFFICULTY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

FOCUS

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

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EVIDENCE PRODUCED

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DIFFICULTY (1) (2) (3) (4) (5)

FOCUS (1) (2) (3) (4) (5)

ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

EVIDENCE I PRODUCED THIS WEEK — LIST IT, NO ADJECTIVES

WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL TODAY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

Halfway is the quietest stretch: the novelty is gone and the mastery hasn't landed.
Return anyway.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

IF THAT HAPPENS, MY PLAN IS

RESOURCE I AM USING — COURSE, BOOK, PERSON, PROJECT

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

STARTENDTOTAL MIN

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID

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DIFFICULTY

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FOCUS

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ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

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DIFFICULTY

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FOCUS

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FOCUS ① ② ③ ④ ⑤

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Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

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EVIDENCE I PRODUCED THIS WEEK — LIST IT, NO ADJECTIVES

WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL TODAY

① ② ③ ④ ⑤ ⑥ ⑦ ⑧ ⑨ ⑩

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

Teach it badly to one person. Nothing finds a gap faster than explaining.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

IF THAT HAPPENS, MY PLAN IS

RESOURCE I AM USING — COURSE, BOOK, PERSON, PROJECT

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Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

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WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

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☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

Consistency is not intensity. It is only ever the act of coming back.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

IF THAT HAPPENS, MY PLAN IS

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FOCUS

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FOCUS

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ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

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EVIDENCE I PRODUCED THIS WEEK — LIST IT, NO ADJECTIVES

WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL TODAY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

You are already better than whoever opened this journal. Make the log prove it.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

IF THAT HAPPENS, MY PLAN IS

RESOURCE I AM USING — COURSE, BOOK, PERSON, PROJECT

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

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☐ Taught it

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DIFFICULTY

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FOCUS

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ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

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EVIDENCE I PRODUCED THIS WEEK — LIST IT, NO ADJECTIVES

WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL TODAY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

Stop collecting resources. You have enough to reach the next level twice over.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

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COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

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THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

Finish something small and real. A finished small thing outranks an unfinished great one.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

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Week debrief

SESSIONS I ACTUALLY RAN

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

EVIDENCE I PRODUCED THIS WEEK — LIST IT, NO ADJECTIVES

WHAT WORKED. KEEP DOING IT.

WHAT DID NOT WORK. STOP DOING IT.

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL TODAY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

1 beginner

10 competent

COMPARED WITH LAST WEEK

☐ Clearly ahead ☐ About even ☐ Behind ☐ Hard to tell

THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

Week brief

A skill is not a finish line. It is the new floor you get to stand on.

WEEK OF _____ TO _____

THIS WEEK'S FOCUS — ONE SENTENCE

THE REP I AM REPEATING ALL WEEK

EVIDENCE I WILL HOLD IN MY HAND BY SUNDAY

SESSIONS PLANNED

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THE THING MOST LIKELY TO DERAIL ME THIS WEEK

IF THAT HAPPENS, MY PLAN IS

RESOURCE I AM USING — COURSE, BOOK, PERSON, PROJECT

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

START

END

TOTAL MIN

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID

FRICTION LOG — EXACTLY WHERE I GOT STUCK

THE FIX I WILL TRY NEXT TIME

EVIDENCE PRODUCED

☐ Made something

☐ Practised

☐ Taught it

☐ Applied it

☐ Failed usefully

DIFFICULTY

12345

FOCUS

12345

ONE LINE I DO NOT WANT TO FORGET

TODAY'S REP — THE ONE THING I AM PRACTISING

START

END

TOTAL MIN

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID

FRICTION LOG — EXACTLY WHERE I GOT STUCK

THE FIX I WILL TRY NEXT TIME

EVIDENCE PRODUCED

☐ Made something ☐ Practised ☐ Taught it ☐ Applied it ☐ Failed usefully

DIFFICULTY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

FOCUS

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

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DIFFICULTY

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

FOCUS

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

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THE ONE CHANGE I AM MAKING NEXT WEEK

YOU MADE IT

The twelve-week debrief

Seventy-two possible sessions ago you signed a charter on page 13. Go and read it before you fill this in.

SESSIONS I RAN, HONESTLY, OUT OF SEVENTY-TWO

WHERE I WAS IN WEEK ONE

WHERE I AM NOW — IN SPECIFICS, NOT FEELINGS

THE SINGLE THING THAT MOVED THE NEEDLE MOST

WHAT GENUINELY SURPRISED ME

THE WEEK IT NEARLY FELL APART, AND WHAT SAVED IT

WHAT I WOULD TELL SOMEONE STARTING THIS JOURNAL TOMORROW

WHERE I AM ON THIS SKILL NOW

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

1 beginner 10 competent

AGAINST THE BASELINE ON PAGE 14, WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGED

WHAT I CAN NOW DO THAT I COULD NOT DO TWELVE WEEKS AGO

WHAT IS STILL OUT OF REACH — AND WHETHER I CARE

THE PIECE OF EVIDENCE I AM PROUDEST OF

DO I KEEP GOING WITH THIS SKILL, OR BANK IT AND MOVE ON?

Evidence ledger

Hours are not progress. This page is progress. Log every real thing you made, shipped, fixed, taught or performed.

	DATE	WHAT I MADE OR DID	WHERE IT LIVES
01			
02			
03			
04			
05			
06			
07			
08			
09			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
15			

EVIDENCE LEDGER · CONTINUED

	DATE	WHAT I MADE OR DID	WHERE IT LIVES
01			
02			
03			
04			
05			
06			
07			
08			
09			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
15			
16			
17			
18			
19			
20			

Resource log

Courses, books, videos, tools, people. Rate them after you finish them — and be willing to write “no” in the last column.

TYPE	NAME	COST	WORTH IT?

RESOURCE LOG • CONTINUED

[illegible]

Wins and breakthroughs

The moment something clicked, someone noticed, or a thing you could not do became a thing you could. You will forget these. Write them down.

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED
01	
02	
03	
04	
05	
06	
07	
08	
09	
10	
11	
12	
13	
14	
15	
16	

Stuck → solved

Pull the repeats out of your Friction Logs. The same obstacle showing up three times is not bad luck — it is the next thing to learn.

[illegible]

People and asks

Skills travel through people faster than through documentation. Keep a list of who helped, and a list of what you still need to ask.

WHO HELPED, AND HOW

QUESTIONS I STILL NEED TO ASK SOMEONE

☐

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☐

DO NOT STOP HERE

Your next twelve weeks

The end of a journal is the worst possible moment to stop. Decide the next thing while the habit is still warm.

-
- ☐ Go deeper on the same skill ☐ Take skill B from page 11
 - ☐ Combine this with something I already have ☐ Teach this skill to someone else
 - ☐ Turn it into work that pays

NEXT SKILL, OR NEXT LEVEL OF THIS ONE

THE FIRST REP OF THE NEXT TWELVE WEEKS

WHAT I AM KEEPING FROM THIS JOURNAL THAT WORKED

WHAT I AM CHANGING ABOUT HOW I PRACTISE

One skill, one journal. The next skill starts on page one of a fresh one.

SIGNED

DATE

ABOUT

The Skill Seeker Lab

The Skill Seeker Lab exists for one stubborn problem: most people know roughly what they want to be good at, and almost nobody has a structure for getting there.

So we build structures. Short ones, with blanks in them. This journal is the paper version — twelve weeks, seventy-two sessions, one skill, and a Friction Log that tells you the truth.

If it worked for you, the most useful thing you can do is tell one other person which page mattered.

KEEP GOING

The Skill Seeker Journal

The Skill Seeker Lab · 2026

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